The short answer is, it is difficult. Traditional telltale signs of lying are shifting gaze to avoid eye contact, folding and unfolding arms, shrugging shoulders, and fidgety hands and feet. However, scientific studies do not support these beliefs. Some honest people are generally nervous and squirmy. In others, these signs show someone is concentrating on being trustworthy.

Polygraph, or "lie detector," machines—which record pulse and breathing rates, blood pressure, and sweating—have a dubious history. This is partly due to the stress of using them. Innocent but anxious people can show up as deceitful, while calm, skilled liars pass easily.

Clues from speech

Speech can be slightly more reliable. Hesitation, repeated words or phrases, breaking up sentences, a change in tone or in speaking speed, vagueness, and describing trivial details while avoiding the main topic—are all strategies to give the brain "time to think" and figure out which falsehood might be most believable. This is especially true for persistent liars, who must access memory so as not to contradict themselves as their multiple deceptions become ever more tangled.

A more reliable method involves the use of fMRI (see p.43), a brain scan that requires the person's total cooperation. Certain parts of the brain are more active when lying and show up together on screen. These include the prefrontal, parietal, and anterior cingulate cortices and the caudate nucleus, thalamus, and amygdala.

In summary:

- **Be very aware of judging someone you don't know well.**
- **Don't rely on time-honored signs such as fidgeting and lack of eye contact.**
- **Clues from speech, such as hesitation and repetition, can be slightly more reliable.**
- **In many tests, a simple "gut feeling" was as successful as most other methods.**